

instance in a scenario when the ‘guest’ system falls prey to a hacking attempt, the ‘host’ will remain safe, and the ‘guest’ can then be safely detached from the ‘host’.

VMware Workstation, Oracle VirtualBox, QEMU are a few virtualization systems that are preferred by professionals.

Part 1: Setting up VMWare and Windows XP VM

First, we need to download and install VMWare Workstation. This is a fairly simple process. You just need to go their website and download the installer, run it as administrator and complete the setup. If you encounter any problem during the installation process, they have got a pretty handy guide to help you with it.

After the installation is done, our next step is to VMWare image of a Windows OS on which we’ll simulate our attacks. We have a variety of options on our hands, but we’ll try to choose those operating systems which are known to have a healthy number of security issues which we could exploit. So, Windows XP and Vista should be your preferred choice. The images are provided by Microsoft itself through their official website and are also easily available on the rest of the internet.

After downloading the image which would probably be an ISO file, open VMWare workstation, click on **File > New virtual machine** and then select your downloaded ISO image. A bunch of instructions will guide you through the process. To tinker with other hardware settings like RAM and memory, you can select the ‘Customize hardware’ button and make the necessary adjustments.

Select the “Power on this virtual machine after creation” option and click the “Next” button and within a few minutes, you’ll have your Windows machine up and running.

Part 2: Configuring insecure web applications

We’ll host a vulnerable web application on our virtualized Windows XP, and for this, we’ll use Damn Vulnerable Web Applications (DVWA).

Why DVWA?

Let’s hear it from them, “Damn Vulnerable Web App (DVWA) is a PHP/MySQL web application that is damn vulnerable. Its main goals are to be an aid for security professionals to test their skills and tools